

Odia and German are cousins. Tamil is not — and still says *amma*.

Every word below means **mother**. They fall into two families that have never been related to each other. Both families arrived at an **m**.

Family one · Indo-European

One ancestor language, spoken north of the Black Sea about 6,000 years ago. Nobody wrote it down — linguists reconstructed it backwards from its children.

RECONSTRUCTED ANCESTOR

***méh₂tēr**

ODIA ମା <i>maa</i>	HINDI माँ <i>maa</i>	SANSKRIT मातृ <i>mātr</i>	GREEK μήτηρ <i>mētēr</i>
LATIN mater <i>mah-ter</i>	GERMAN Mutter <i>moo-ter</i>	SPANISH madre <i>mah-dreh</i>	FRENCH mère <i>mehr</i>

Family two · Dravidian

Older in India than the family above, and completely unrelated to it. All four are spoken next door to Odisha.

RECONSTRUCTED ANCESTOR

***amma**

TAMIL அம்மா <i>ammaa</i>	TELUGU అమ్మ <i>amma</i>	KANNADA ಅಮ್ಮ <i>amma</i>	MALAYALAM അമ്മ <i>amma</i>
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So why do both families sound the same?

Because babies do. **M** is the easiest consonant a human mouth makes — lips together, no tongue required, and it works while feeding. Babies everywhere produce it first, and everywhere adults decide the baby means *her*.

Two unrelated families, thousands of miles apart, both built their word for mother out of the same accident. Linguists call these **nursery words** — and they are the one place where a resemblance between languages proves nothing at all.

Now go and check. Ask the German, Spanish and French tables for *two*, *three* and *night* — that is where the resemblance shows up fastest. Odia: ଦୁଇ *dui*, ତିନି *tini*, ରାତି *raati*.